Literature: Legends and Romances

H 1795

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A. Background

Uniform titles for the texts of legends and romances and personal name records for individual legendary characters are established in the name authority file (NAF). For example, a French medieval epic poem is represented by the following uniform title in the NAF: ***Guillaume (Chanson de geste)*** [tagged 130]. A character featured in this work is represented by the personal name heading ***William of Palerne (Legendary character)*** [tagged 100] in the name authority file. Both are valid for subject use.

Objects or named groups of characters that are part of a legend or romance are established as subject headings in the *Library of Congress Subject Headings* (LCSH).

This instruction sheet provides guidelines for establishing subject headings for objects and named groups of legendary characters, as well as for assigning subject headings and uniform titles to texts of, and to works about, legends and romances.

Until July 2013, headings for individual legendary characters were established as subject headings in LCSH. Headings for individual legendary characters are now established as RDA

name authority records in the NAF. As noted above, objects and groups of legendary characters continue to be established in LCSH.

Existing LCSH headings remain valid for use as subjects until name authority records for the characters are created and the subject authority records are cancelled. Establish RDA name headings for characters when they are needed for use as descriptive access points. Optionally, name headings may be established when the characters are needed only as subject headings. In either case, make a proposal to cancel the existing subject heading following the instructions in H 193, section E.

Also make proposals to cancel phrase headings based on the heading for the character when the phrase will be replaced by a ***[heading]--[free-floating subdivision]*** combination, unless the heading is needed for a hierarchy (i.e., the subdivided heading is a broader term reference for another heading).

Make proposals to revise phrase headings based on the heading for the character when the phrase will be replaced by a ***[heading]--[subdivision]*** combination in which the subdivision is not free-floating.

LC practice: As stated in H 1075, LC catalogers will no longer use form subdivisions. Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from the Library of Congress Genre/Form Terms (LCGFT), e.g. ***Legends***, ***Romances***, etc.

B. Recent revisions

2026-02: Updated template. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.

C. Definitions

Legends: Traditional narratives generally regarded by their tellers as true. They may include narratives that are religious (such as those that are associated with the lives of saints or martyrs, religious objects or beings); supernatural (for example, vampires, werewolves, or ghosts); about individuals (for example, national figures or heroes); or about specific places (such as emphasizing place name origins or folk histories).

Romances: Medieval chivalric tales written in prose or poetry that depict an idealized code of civilized behavior that combines loyalty, honor, and courtly love.

D. Establishing subject headings for named groups of legendary characters or objects

D.1. General rule

Establish headings for named groups of legendary characters according to the following pattern:

150 ## $a [*name of group*] (Legendary characters)

450 ## $a [*alternative form of name, if any*] (Legendary characters)

550 ## $w g $a Folklore [*or, if appropriate,* Legends] $z Place

Code the heading as ***not*** subdivided geographically by selecting the ***Not Subd Geog*** radio button on the template in the Subject Heading Proposal System.

Examples:

150 ## $a Kayānids (Legendary characters)

450 ## $a Kayānians (Legendary characters)

450 ## $a Kayāniyān (Legendary characters)

550 ## $w g $a Legends $z Iran

150 ## $a Horatii (Legendary characters)

550 ## $w g $a Legends $z Rome

D.2. Legendary objects

Use no qualifier after headings for legendary objects, for example, ***Grail***.

E. Assignment of headings

Note: In carrying out the following procedures, treat headings for gods, goddesses, and mythological characters, i.e., those that are qualified ***(… deities)*** or ***(… mythology)*** in the same manner as legendary characters.

E.1. Texts

Assign to literary versions of legendary tales, whether individual or collected, and whether in prose, verse, or dramatic form, the heading designating the dominant character or motif of the tale, with the form subdivision ***--Legends*** or***--Romances***. Use these subdivisions under name headings for real persons and legendary characters. Also assign additional headings appropriate for folklore materials (cf. H 1627) or for individual works of drama, fiction, or poetry (cf. H 1780, H 1790, H 1800).

Use the form subdivision ***--Romances*** under names of persons and legendary characters for the texts of medieval (i.e., pre-1501) European tales based chiefly on legends of chivalric love and adventure. (Exception: Use ***Arthurian romances*** as a form heading instead of ***Arthur, King--Romances***.) In all other cases, including sagas, use the form subdivision ***--Legends***.

Also use these subdivisions for works that are clearly modern language retellings of legends and romances of medieval origin, with characters and plots that are essentially unaltered. If the modern version is changed so substantially that it is, in effect, a new work, unrecognizable as a retelling of a medieval work, use instead the standard literary form subdivisions***--Fiction***, ***--Drama***, ***--Poetry***, or ***--Literary collections***, in accordance with the provisions of H 1780, H 1790, and H 1800.

LC practice: Do not use a form subdivision of the type ***--Legends*** or ***--Romances*.** Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from LCGFT, e.g. ***Legends***, ***Romances***, etc.

Example:

```
600 00 $a Yvain $c (Legendary character) $v Romances.
```

LC practice:

```
600 00 $a Yvain $c (Legendary character)
655 #7 $a Arthurian romances. $2 lcgft
```

Example:

```
600 00 $a Miaoshan $c (Legendary character) $v Legends.
```

LC practice:

```
600 00 $a Miaoshan $c (Legendary character)
655 #7 $a Legends. $2 lcgft
```

Example:

```
600 00 $a Veronica, $c Saint, $d active 1st century $v Legends.
```

LC practice:

```
600 00 $a Veronica, $c Saint, $d active 1st century.
655 #7 $a Legends. $2 lcgft
```

Example:

```
650 #0 $a Grail $v Legends.
```

LC practice:

```
650 #0 $a Grail.
655 #7 $a Legends. $2 lcgft
```

E.2. History and criticism of legends and romances

Assign headings of the type described above, further subdivided by ***--History and criticism*** (or by other appropriate subdivisions used under literary form headings, such as ***--Concordances*** or ***--Indexes***.

LC practice: Do not use a form subdivision of the type ***--Concordances*** or ***--Indexes*.** Instead, assign an appropriate term or terms from LCGFT, e.g. ***Concordances***, ***Indexes***, etc.

Examples:

```
650 #0 $a Grail $x Legends $x History and criticism.


650 #0 $a Arthurian romances $v Indexes.
```

LC practice:

```
650 #0 $a Arthurian romances.
655 #7 $a Indexes. $2 lcgft


600 00 $a Arthur, $c King $x Romances $v Concordances.
```

LC practice:

```
600 00 $a Arthur, $c King $x Romances.
655 #7 $a Concordances. $2 lcgft
```

To works about a specific legend or romance, or a specific version of a legend or romance, also assign the appropriate uniform title or name-title headings.

Example:

```
Title: Three studies of Sir Gawain and the Green Knight.
630 00 $a Gawain and the Grene Knight.
600 00 $a Gawain $c (Legendary character) $x Romances $x History and
       criticism.
```

E.3. History and criticism of individual legendary characters

To general works that focus on a specific legendary character rather than on the legend(s) or romance(s) in which the character appears, assign the heading for the character and use no literary form subdivision after the heading. If the discussion is limited to the presence of the character in literature or art, assign the heading ***[*name of character*]--In literature***, or ***[*name of character*]--Art***. The subdivisions ***--In literature*** and ***--Art*** are free-floating under names of legendary characters.

F. Examples

Title: The Pied Piper of Hamlin.

600 00 $a Pied Piper of Hamelin $c (Legendary character) $v Legends.

650 #0 $a Legends $z Germany $z Hameln.

651 #0 $a Hameln (Germany) $x History $v Fiction.

LC practice:

600 00 $a Pied Piper of Hamelin $c (Legendary character)

650 #0 $a Legends $z Germany $z Hameln.

651 #0 $a Hameln (Germany) $x History.

655 #7 $a Legends. $2 lcgft

655 #7 $a Fiction. $2 lcgft

Title: Heracles and Euripidean tragedy.

650 #0 $a Greek drama (Tragedy) $x History and criticism.

600 00 $a Euripides. $t Heracles.

600 00 $a Heracles $c (Greek mythological character) $x In literature.

Title: A natural man : the true story of John Henry.

600 10 $a Henry, John $c (Legendary character)

Revision history

2026-02: Updated template. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.